

Pronouns

PRONOUN MEANS “FOR A NOUN,” AND A PRONOUN IS A WORD THAT TAKES THE PLACE OF A NOUN.

Without pronouns, spoken and written English would be very repetitive. Once a noun has been referred to by its actual name once, another word—a pronoun—can be used to stand for this name.

Using pronouns

If the full name of a noun were used each time it had to be referred to, sentences would be long and confusing. Pronouns are useful because they make sentences shorter and therefore clearer. The noun is still required when someone or something is referred to for the first time.

Rita loves playing the **guitar**.
She finds **it** relaxing.

noun noun

This personal pronoun represents *Rita*, the subject.

This personal pronoun represents *playing the guitar*, the object.

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Types of pronouns

There are seven types of pronouns, which are used for different purposes. Do not confuse these with determiners or adjectives, which modify rather than replace nouns.

Personal pronouns

These **represent people, places, or things**. They vary according to whether the noun being replaced is the subject of a sentence (performing the action) or the object (receiving the action).

I, you, he, she, it, we, you, they (subject)
me, you, him, her, it, us, you, them (object)

This pronoun represents the singular subject.

She gave **them** a guitar lesson.

This pronoun represents the plural object.

Possessive pronouns

These **show ownership and replace possessive** noun phrases. Don't get these confused with possessive determiners such as *my* and *your*, which precede but do not replace the noun.

mine, yours, his, hers, its, ours, yours, theirs

This pronoun replaces the possessive noun phrase *Rita's guitar*.

The guitar is **hers**.

Relative pronouns

These **link one part of a sentence to another** by introducing a relative clause that describes an earlier noun or pronoun.

who, whom, whose, which, that, what

Rita is the person who plays the guitar.

This pronoun is describing *Rita*, the subject.

Reflexive pronouns

These **refer back to an earlier noun or pronoun** in a sentence, so the performing and receiving of an action apply to the same person or thing. They cannot be used without the noun or pronoun that they relate to.

myself, yourself, himself, herself, ourselves, themselves

This pronoun refers back to the earlier pronoun *she*.

She taught **herself**.



• **I** is the only pronoun that is spelled with a **capital** letter.